

# READING THE CARDS

## the tarot

Today familiar as a tool for fortune-telling—a form of divination—tarot cards originated in Europe in the early 15th century. Ordinary playing cards are believed to have come to Europe from Mamluk in Egypt a century earlier, and tarot was simply a variation. These early tarot cards were used purely for entertainment, and the name “tarot” comes from a game similar to bridge that was played with them in Italy called *tarocchi* (fool or joker).

The four suits in these early tarot cards were batons (later wands), coins (later pentacles), swords, and cups. Around 1440, special cards with allegorical illustrations were added to the tarot suits to create decks called *carte da trionfi* (triumph cards)—trump cards in English. At first the cards were hand-painted and rare, but after the invention of the printing press they were mass-produced.

### Ancient Egyptian occult origins

In 1773, French scholar Antoine Court de Gébelin began writing a pivotal book called *Le Monde primitif* (“The Primitive World”) about the ancestry of languages. Gébelin argued that tarot symbols were based on the mysterious ancient Egyptian text, the *Book of Thoth*. He also suggested that the Catholic

Church had tried to suppress this knowledge, but that it had spread via the Romany people. There was little evidence to support his theories, and Books of Thoth since translated contain nothing resembling tarot. However, Gébelin’s work sparked a fascination with tarot’s occult possibilities.

### Use for divination

A decade later another Frenchman, Jean-Baptiste Alliette, wrote a book on how to use tarot cards for divination, and issued a set of cards. He called the book *Etteilla, ou L’art de lire dans les cartes* (“Etteilla, or The Art of Reading Cards”)—“Etteilla” being his own name spelled backward. Alliette established tarot divination as a popular pursuit for the first time. He divined using a deck of just 32 cards with the addition of his own special Etteilla card, known as “the significator,” which usually represented the person consulting the tarot reader.



### ▲ All in the cards

Jean-Baptiste Alliette’s 19th-century Etteilla cards were the first set of tarot cards designed exclusively for divination. Their assigned meaning changes depending on the orientation of the card.

### IN CONTEXT

## Consulting the stars

Astrology plays a significant role in how tarot cards and the positions they occupy in a reading (known as “spreads”) are interpreted. This connection was established in the late 19th century by a secret society of British occultists called the Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn (see pp.242–243). The Order drew links between the tarot suits, each of the astrological signs, and the four classic elements. Fire is associated with the signs Aries, Leo, and Sagittarius, and the suit of Wands; Earth is affiliated with Taurus, Virgo, and Capricorn, and the suit of Pentacles; Air has links with Gemini, Libra, and Aquarius, and the suit of Swords; and Water goes with Cancer, Scorpio, and Pisces, and the suit of Cups.

**The Moon (associated with Pisces)**, in this 15th-century example painted by Italian Antonio Cicognara, was one of the original cards of the tarot deck.

